

A

Phrasal verbs with no object

Some phrasal verbs don't have an object. We cannot put other words between the parts of the verb.

When does your train **get in** [arrive]?

Hold on [wait a moment], I just need to get my coat.

The car **broke down** on my way to work. [stopped working]

I'll **call for** them at 8 o'clock. [go to collect them]

We **set off** [started the journey] about 7.30.

B

Phrasal verbs with an object

Many phrasal verbs need an object. We can usually put the object in different positions.

Put on your shoes.

Turn on the TV.

Take off your coat.

Put your shoes **on**.

Turn the TV **on**.

Take your coat **off**.

These are separable phrasal verbs, but if the object is a long phrase, it usually goes at the end, e.g. I **turned off** the lights in the living room. If the object is a pronoun, it must go in the middle, e.g. **Turn it off**.

Common mistakes

Put them on. (NOT Put ~~on~~ them.); **Take it off.** (NOT Take ~~off~~ it.)

There are some phrasal verbs where the object must come after the phrasal verb.

I will **look after** the children for you. [take care of them]

How did the two men **break into** the shop? [enter the shop using force, e.g. breaking a window]

C

In dictionaries

Dictionaries usually show the grammar of a phrasal verb like this:

No object	hang around <i>(also UK hang about)</i> to spend time somewhere, usually without doing very much: <i>There's nowhere for teenagers to go, so they just hang around on street corners.</i>
Separable	hand sth out to give something to all the people in a group: <i>A girl was handing out leaflets at the station.</i>
Not separable (the object must come after the phrasal verb)	get over sth to begin to feel better after being unhappy or ill: <i>It took her months to get over the shock of Richard leaving.</i>

D

Style

Phrasal verbs are commonly used in spoken and written English. Many phrasal verbs are quite informal, and sometimes there is a single word with the same meaning as a phrasal verb, which sounds more formal. We use this word instead of the phrasal verb in more formal situations.

leave sb/sth out [not include sb/sth; *syn omit*], e.g. He made a list of people but left me out.

make sth up [create sth from your imagination; *syn invent*], e.g. We had to make up a story.

put sth off [put sth back to a later date; *syn postpone*], e.g. They put the game off till Friday.

turn sth/sb down [refuse an offer or request; *syn reject*], e.g. I offered her a job but she turned it down.